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The Yale Political Monthly

An Undergraduate Publication

Present at the Re–Creation
An Interview with Paul Nitze on the New World Order

Latter Day Toxic Avengers
Are Connecticut Residents Creating Their Own Waste Disposal Crisis?

Satisfying the National Urge
The Case for a Federal Sex Education Policy

Observations
Mexico's PRI: Is the Party Really Over?

Letters
A Debate on Multicultural Science

Celebrating Fifteen Years of Publication

VOLUME 15, NUMBER 3 ❦ MAY 1994

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We encourage responses and will print all thoughtful and well-written letters with appropriate authorial response in the hope of stimulating continued dialogue on campus. All written material should be submitted to the Editor or mailed to the YPM. Students wishing to join the staff of the YPM should contact the Editor at 436-1043.

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7242 Yale Station
New Haven, Conn. 06520

PAST EDITORS OF THE YPM

Robert Kagan (1979-1980)
Joseph Rose (1980-1981)
Michael Froomkin (1981-1982)
Diana West (1982-1983)
Gideon Rose (1983-1985)
Fareed Zakaria (1985-1986)
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Kimberly Kessler (1990-1991)
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Jeff Campione (1992-1993)

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VOLUME 15, NUMBER 3
MAY, 1994

Observations:
4 Mexico's PRI: Is the party really over?

Many may judge in the wake of the passage of NAFTA that Mexico's largest political party, PRI, will lose its hold over Mexican politics. The situation, however, is not as clear-cut as it appears.

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Community activists all over the country have mobilized against low level radioactive waste disposal facilities being built near their communities. In protesting against permanent sites, however, Americans may be putting themselves in more danger than necessary.

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The problems of the rise in the incidence of teenage pregnancy and the increase in the number of AIDS cases amongst school-age children continue to build, with no apparent solution in sight. It is imperative that Congress fund a standardized, mandatory, and content-regulated sex education program nationwide in order to confront these problems.

Observations

4

Mexico's ruling party, the PRI (Institutional Revolutionary Party), has held a virtual monopoly on political power since 1928. Two recent developments, however, have jolted the Mexican political landscape. First, the Chiapas uprising spoiled President Salinas' plans to celebrate the inauguration of NAFTA (North American Free Trade Agreement). To compound the PRI's woes, Salinas' hand–picked successor, Luis Donaldo Colosio, was assassinated only weeks later. Consequently, many observers now believe that such tumult will finally force the PRI to embrace meaningful political reform — and thereby forswear its longtime hegemony. If only the PRI shared such noble intentions.

Mexico remains a Third World country in spite of its First World aspirations

On first glance, it seemed that the PRI had become a victim of its own success at liberalizing the economy. Under Salinas, Mexico privatized industries, cut government spending, and opened its markets to the US and Canada. These IMF–approved reforms, coupled with heavy foreign investment, not only secured economic gains for Mexico, but also conferred legitimacy upon the PRI. Yet Salinas failed to provide an adequate safety net for his reforms, which benefited professionals and industrialists at the poor's expense. Discontent especially smoldered among peasants in Chiapas, whose earnings stood further to plummet as imports of cheaper American grain would rise under NAFTA.

The Chiapas uprising and Colosio's untimely demise have undoubtably weakened the PRI. Under international pressure, Salinas began to negotiate with the *Zapatista* rebels. Meanwhile, rumors that a PRI cabal conspired against Colosio have only heightened national turmoil. Yet despite its recent travails, the PRI will, in all likelihood, remain entrenched in the national political arena.

Any political benefits accruing from NAFTA will only strengthen Mexico's single–party tradition

The PRI has mastered the art of dividing and conquering an already fractured opposition. Only two parties offer legitimate alternatives to the PRI. The conservative PAN (National Action Party) favors increasing the Catholic Church's role in government. Salinas' economic successes, however, have weakened the PAN's traditional support base. To the left stands the populist PRD (Democratic Revolution Party). Its 1988 presidential nominee, Cuahtemoc Cárdenas, narrowly lost to Salinas in an election marked by widespread fraud and vote–rigging. Yet the PRD does not currently pose a threat to the PRI. Internal squabbling, as well as its refusal to negotiate with PRI, limit the PRD's ability to play a substantial role in government.

The PRI also derives considerable strength from its ability to co–opt potential threats to its hegemony. By including influential sectors of society within its ranks, the PRI can appease diverse constituencies. The president, who mediates between competing ideological factions, sets the PRI's political agenda. PRI's reputation for victory allows it to woo the most attractive and popular candidates; for example, PRI attracts the Ivy League–educated technocrats such as Salinas who hold the real influence in government.

Meaningful reform will only occur either if the opposition assumes the powerful Mexican presidency, or if the PRI splits into competing parties. Although Cárdenas came close to accomplishing the first scenario in 1988, the present ineptitude of the opposition renders this unlikely. Furthermore, given the president's prodigious influence over his party and the government, the second seems as unlikely as the first. Thus far, the PRI has offered at best token measures to the opposition, such as guaranteeing legislative seats to minority parties. As long as the PRI commands legislative majorities, however, such gestures will prove to be moot.

Mexico remains a Third World country in spite of its First World aspirations. The sleek skyline of Mexico City stands in stark contrast to the capital's impoverished slums and Chiapas' thatched huts. The *Zapatista* uprising merely underscored the social costs of modernizing too rapidly. As a matter of fact, the rebellion hardly came as any surprise to knowledgeable Mexicans, for Chiapas has long suffered from chronic land disputes between peasants and rural bosses. As such, Chiapas represents only a temporary, albeit disquieting, setback from which the PRI can recover. In this regard, Colosio's death may actually attract a sympathy vote for the PRI in the upcoming election; his replacement, Yale–educated Ernesto Zedillo, promises to continue Salinas' policies upon his election.

That the PRI will continue to rule Mexico calls into question the prevalent expectation, that economic liberalization will in itself bring about more democratic regimes. Unfortunately, the PRI does not pay heed to such notions. Rather, by promoting steady economic growth, the PRI hopes to secure sufficient support such that it may *hinder* further attempts to democratize Mexico's political structure. In this light, any political benefits accruing from NAFTA will only strengthen Mexico's single–party tradition. Despite Mexico's current unrest, one simply cannot write off an institution which has tenaciously clung to power for over 65 years. If Mexico does ultimately persevere into a truly democratic system, it will have succeeded in spite of — and not because of — the PRI.

The PRI is dead: long live the PRI.

— Nick Quezada BK '96

Letters

DEAR SIR — The essay by Kimberly Kagan is a thoughtful and discerning examination of claims that multicultural perspectives would provide powerful new insights into science. Her judgment in these matters is very good, for it agrees with mine. Nevertheless, had I written a similar critique I would have been more forceful and specific.

The advocates of multicultural perspectives in science have borrowed or generated a number of declarations of purported cosmic import, which on examination in specific circumstances turn out to be banalities or superficial platitudes. For example, we are told that "facts are not unsullied bits of information." Let us look at an important fact in science. The velocity of light is 299,792,458 meters per second. The fact has been established by scientists from the European–American geocultural group. In what respect would it change if viewed from the perspective of Asian, Pacific Islander, Black/African–American, Hispanic/Chicano/Puerto Rican/Latino or American Indian/Native American geocultural groups? Take another. Two grams of hydrogen combine with 16 grams of oxygen to produce 18 grams of water. In what way would cultural affiliation change this fact? Or consider a third. A molecule of hemoglobin has a mass 64,000 times that of an atom of hydrogen. Would this ratio change if we listened "more diligently to non–traditional voices?"

Turning to a few of the fundamental laws, theories or concepts of modern science, for example, those of celestial and terrestrial mechanics, thermodynamics, molecular structure, genetics, all created by Europeans and their descendants, what differences in formulation and expression arise from a "unique ethnic minority perspective?"

We are also repeatedly bombarded by the assertion that "science is a social construction." Again let us look at a specific issue. The fine structure constant of (spectroscopy in) physics was 137 in the 1920s, 137.04 in the 1940s and 137.035989561 in the 1980s. In what way was this progression a social construction? The laws of classical thermodynamics can be expressed in words as "the energy of the world is a constant; the entropy tends toward a maximum." Relatively theory leads to $E = mc^2$. What fresh insights into these concepts are provided by the assertion that they are social constructions?

In a banal sense, of course science is a social construction. It is constructed by human beings. A human being, even a hermit, is affected by environment from conception onward, and other human beings are integral components of the environment. We all have essentially the same DNA. We are all interlocked even to the air we breathe in comon. As one astute scientist pointed out, every breath one inhales contains 20 oxygen molecules from the last breath exhaled by the dying Julius Caesar.

Ultimately we must recognize that a string of slogans is not a syllogism.

— Irving M. Klotz
Northwestern University

THE AUTHOR RESPONDS — I am most grateful to Professor Klotz for his kind response. I agree unreservedly that it is critically important to attack and refute any attempts to revise fundamental laws, principles, theorems, physical constants, measurements, etc., on the premise that there is a "unique ethnic minority perspective on science." *The Portland Baseline Essays* are particularly vulnerable to this attack, and it is important to root out and destroy all of the nonsense that is contained therein. The movement for multiculturalism in science is broader and more complex, however, than the afrocentrism and willingness to distort observable facts of *The Baseline Essays on Science*. Although the people who attended the AAAF conference are in fact part of the same movement, it is essential to understand the differences between the positions they hold and those held by the author of *The Baseline Essay on Science*.

Whereas *The Baseline Essay on Science* contains numerous factual errors and distortions, I have not located any factual distortions concerning the central principles and laws of science in the AAAF report. Specifically, it does not assert that the speed of light varies depending upon the "ethnicity" of the observer; neither does it contain any assertions of the variety Professor Klotz describes. The trouble of attacking this study by proposing and debunking a number of possible concrete examples of the effects of the "ethnic minority perspective on science" is that the backers of the AAAF report will almost certainly simply dissociate themselves from whatever particular "examples" which are so destroyed. In fact, one of the most notable characteristics of this report is that it contains no specifics at all concerning what the "ethnic minority perspective on science" would consist of or what concrete effects it might have. It is, in fact, precisely the lack of such specifics which makes it much more dangerous than *The Baseline Essays on Science* and similar overt misrepresentations of fact.

What makes the AAAF report especially dangerous is its coherent and "logical" justifcation of the existence of an "ethnic minority perspective

on science." Not only is this justification based on a number of deductions from premises which may well be sound, but because most people still believe that science is an objective discipline, the very fact that such a viewpoint emerges from such a discipline will lend it greater credibility. The credibility will carry the conclusion that minorities have a "unique perspective" on things in general into other fields and will thereby strengthen movements which are already striving to descredit truth entirely in history, literature, and sociology, fields in which the subjective element is very strong.

The danger to science is not the risk that the proponents of the "ethnic minority perspective on science" will convince American scientists as a body, or even in any significant number, that the force of gravity is anything other than 9.8 meters per square second. The real dangers are more insidious. The most immediate is that science curricula will be required to change to accomodate the "ethnic minority perspective on science" discovered by the AAAF conference at the expense of serious scientific education. These curricula are likely to be less radical and counter–factual than *The Baseline Essays on Science*, and more acceptable to parents and school boards in the public schools. The result will be yet another dilution of a curriculum which is already thin compared with the other leading industrialized nations of the world.

In short, it is important for a wide variety of reasons to attack the general principle that minorities think differently merely because of the color of their skin. The damage caused by the assertion of that principle will not be confined to science, and, therefore, attacks which are aimed solely at its scientific manefestations will leave untouched other equally destructive manefestations in other fields.

Dear sir — My compliments to your publication! I find the features therein challenging, interesting, and stimulating. Thought–provoking articles are addressed by obviously well–prepared writers. You have every right to be indeed proud of a most commendable effort by all concerned!

— The Honorable Tom Vandergriff
Former U.S. Representative of Texas
Congressional District 26 and currently
County Judge, Tarrant County, Texas

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Present at the Re–Creation
An Interview with Paul Nitze

Paul H. Nitze has devoted over half a century to public service. In 1950 Nitze was principal author of NSC–68, a classified document that laid the groundwork for the American policy of containment. Subsequently, he served as Secretary of Navy for LBJ. A lifelong Democrat, Nitze nevertheless maintained a nonpartisan approach to crafting security policy. During the Reagan administration, he served as chief negotiator to the Intermediate–Range Nuclear Talks, which culminated in the 1988 INF treaty with the USSR. Nitze now maintains an office at the Paul H. Nitze School of Advanced International Studies, which he co–founded. On 18 March, *YPM* editor Gautam Dutta interviewed this distinguished statesman.

Q: Ironically, one of the more controversial chapters of the Cold War concerns what brought about its very conclusion. In this regard, how important was the role of Reagan's arms control policies in producing this outcome?

A: I thought Reagan's restoration of American self–confidence was particularly important. Americans tended to be discouraged at the beginning of Reagan's tour of duty. Then he picked up all of us who were lacking in self–confidence and demonstrated his firm belief in the superiority of our political system and economy [compared to] that of the Soviet Union. I think Reagan's confidence in US superiority affected everybody who was associated with it, for it reversed that feeling of malaise and gave us all a great deal of renewed confidence. My Russian friends tell me that his calling the Soviet empire the "Evil Empire" had more effect upon them than anything else that happened because they knew the accusation to be true, and they couldn't very well rebut it.

Q: So was Reagan's impact a matter of tone?

A: It was a matter of confidence. The President was the focal point around which renewed American confidence in itself was built.

Gautam Dutta is a Senior in Saybrook and Editor of the YPM.

Q: In the end, what unraveled the Soviet Union? A lot of people assert that the USSR had already been imploding, and thus Reagan's policies only accelerated this change. They argue that he made the Soviets spur their defense spending to such an extent that the "Evil Empire" had to unwind and dissolve. Do you agree with this interpretation?

Clinton started off excessively attentive to the swings and moods of the public

A: A very important historical change is the result of a hell of a lot of different forces. Reagan's influence was certainly only one.

Q: How serious a problem do you consider nuclear proliferation in this now unipolar, or perhaps even multipolar, world? In particular, what US policies do you think would best prevent the world's nuclear club from expanding?

A: In my view the government's working at it quite intelligently. I think we're making some degree of progress, but it's the sort of thing that takes a long period of time before it is materially reduced. It's going to be a long time before the Seoul Agreements are fully implemented.

Q: Let me address the problem in North Korea. Do you approve of how the US is currently leaving it to the International Atomic Energy Agency (IAEA) and [IAEA Director] Hans Blix vis–a–vis conducting negotiations with the North Koreans?

Playing footsie with Yeltsin's opponents is the wrong way to handle it today

A: In the past it has been my view that there wasn't any point in negotiating with them. The important point was to make our position clear that if they were ever to use nuclear weapons or even conventional weapons in an aggressive way, we would use appropriate means to see to it that they stopped. I think they have begun to understand that. We want to handle the situation intelligently so that the use of force by anyone doesn't take place. Time is on our side, because the internal economic situation within Korea is such that everybody is close to starvation. I wouldn't be surprised if two years from now, Kim Il Sung will have faded away.

Q: Moving to the former Soviet republics, what do you think of [Secretary of Defense William] Perry's recent initiative with [Russian

Defense Chief] Grachev, in which the Clinton Administration has hedged its bets on Yeltsin by directly dealing with the Russian military, especially with regard to all their nuclear sites?

A: I'd be very careful about doing that. In order to get anything done in the [ex–]USSR today it has to be done by Yeltsin and those that he approves. Playing footsie with his opponents, I think, is the wrong way to handle it today.

Q: In that regard, how do you view the Russian military, given how it considers many [ex–] Soviet republics as "near abroad" and given the interventionist policies on the part of some of its members? Do you think of [the military] as a rogue force?

A: I don't know why you call it a rogue force. It appropriately takes its guidance from those in power in Moscow.

All great Presidents have taken views that differ from the majority of the people at the time

Q: At this point do you think it takes its guidance more from Grachev or more from Yeltsin?

A: I would think more from Yeltsin.

Q: Many observers fear that Russian nuclear facilities are vulnerable to having their parts dismantled for cash, that they are susceptible to terrorist attacks, or that they are simply inadequately protected. Do you find that a problem?

A: Security of their nuclear sites?

Q: Yes. As in the Ukraine or Kazakhstan.

A: I think that issue is a legitimate concern. There are so many gangs and gangsters around here that if they could make money out of stealing a nuclear weapon, they might well do it. I don't think, however, that that's a major threat. Sure the gangs can do a lot of damage with one weapon, but it's entirely different thing if someone has a force that includes delivery systems and intelligent assets and God knows what necessary to mount a really dangerous attack. That takes more than just a weapon or two.



President Ronald Reagan and Paul H. Nitze (courtesy of the Paul H. Nitze School of Advanced International Studies)

Q: How do you view South Asia right now regarding nuclear proliferation? As the arms race between India and Pakistan heats up, the US recently blocked the transfer of some satellite technology to India from Russia. Given India's proven [atomic] capacity, Pakistan's suspected bomb capacity and China's involvement in the background, how serious a threat do you view this region?

A: I think it's a threat. Solving the problem, however, isn't so easy. In my opinion we should continue to take the position that nobody can gain from the use of a nuclear weapon, and this business of trying to profit from threats to use [nuclear weapons] isn't going to do anybody any good. We are going to adopt a very negative attitude toward people who participate in unilateral or bilateral threats regarding the use of nuclear weapons.

Q: Turning to the European theater, could you please discuss briefly the future of NATO, with reference to Clinton's proposed "Partnership for Peace" and/or the CSCE [Conference for Security and Cooperation in Europe]. How can we best help to create an effective security structure for the entire European continent?

A: We already have one. The foundation for anything that requires, or that might require, the use of military power rests almost entirely within the NATO forces. They're the only ones that within a few hours could really mount a major operation. Nobody else has that capability. It would be to the disadvantage of everybody and everybody would recognize that it's to their [sic] disadvantage if somebody else were to try to have comparable powers to that of the NATO forces. We're in pretty good shape on that score.

Q: How should one view countries like Poland or the Czech Republic which seek protection from Russian hegemony?

A: The question or issue is not what they want but what would be good for them and for us and for the world as a whole. I don't think it would be good to go beyond this "Partnership for Peace." It is a very good procedure and I wouldn't even hint that we would propose membership for them at any time.

Q: What has been the effectiveness thus far of Clinton's foreign policy? Has he shortchanged security considerations by paying more attention to domestic priorities?

A: Under the Constitution, the president cannot ignore foreign policy. He's got to deal with

it, either by inaction or by action. He can't avoid the responsibility. Clinton says he wants to give priority to domestic concerns, and I think everybody would agree with that. But he's got to do both at the same time.

Q: In your opinion, has Clinton devoted sufficient attention to foreign policy?

A: No, I don't. I don't think he has given it his full attention and given it time enough.

Q: What suggestions would you offer Clinton at this point to improve his performance?

A: One point I'd make is that he started off excessively attentive to the swings and moods of the public. I think he ought to move away from that and consider that the main thing he has to do is [to] make up his own mind. He ought to take as long a view as possible and then explain to the American people why his view is different from their's. All great Presidents have taken views that differ from the majority of the people at the time and then undertaken, and attempted, and done better or worse, in trying to explain those views to the public.

Q: Clinton has linked most–favored nation status [MFN] renewal to an improved Chinese record on human rights and must arrive at a decision by 3 June. Should the US renew MFN status to China?

A: I believe it's important that we maintain and develop a working relationship with China. I don't think MFN is the most effective way to go about it.

Q: How should the US effectively "go about it?"

A: The US should expand relations with China and resist laying down down ultimata with or without time deadlines. Despite current disagreements, you can [always] express hopes for the future.

Q: I was looking at your distinguished background and this question came to mind. In your view, what would you suggest to best train our future leaders? For example, what should one study in college, how should one approach education, or what should one experience after college with regard to a career? In particular, what do you see as the role of the university in this time and age?

A: It's not important to have a university education. What you need is energy and imagination and an early introduction into active life. Get into the practice of politics early and make your mistakes young, because you learn best by making mistakes and understanding why they were mistakes. Practice should come before theory.

Q: After graduating from Harvard in 1928, you returned to your alma mater nearly ten years later. Why did you embark upon this period of study between 1937 and 1938?

A: I was trying to understand the growth of totalitarianism in Europe that appeared in the forms of Marxism with Stalin, Fascism with Mussolini, and Nazism with Hitler. Frankly I found no one at Harvard who understood a thing about these issues. I think I understood them much better than they did.

Q: How did it feel to be a card–carrying Democrat in a Republican administration? Do you think it altered people's perceptions when they were dealing with you?

A: I don't think it hurt me at all, because I was working on serious matters which should be approached on a non–partisan basis. And it helped to convince people that I was dealing with an objective analysis of the situation rather than promoting party interests.

Q: How would you compare your experiences to that of [White House Counselor] David Gergen now?

A: I think well of Gergen. I think he's currently doing a very good job for the President.

Q: Do you view him more as a dedicated man or someone who is just out to further his own career?

A: I think he's a serious public servant. I don't think there's necessarily any dichotomy, any conflict, between being interested in your own career but also being interested in the things you stand for and trying to have them done as best you can regardless of party. I think Gergen looks at things very much from a non–partisan standpoint.

Q: Let me turn back to security policy. What approach should one take when looking at security issues? You mentioned that one should be bi–partisan, or maybe non–partisan, or in your words, "objective" at the task. What sort of background would be best for being an effective negotiator in arms control policy?

A: It takes interest in the subject and objectivity and patience. I was at the INF [Intermediate Nuclear Forces] negotiations for three or four years [between 1985 and 1988].

Q: When you are thinking of these long–term [security issues], you often must consider the most negative outcome possible, say nuclear conflict. What is the one thing that keeps you going?

A: You don't. It's a mistake to take the most negative [view]. What you want to do is be as objective as you can and keep your mind focused on the most positive, reasonable goal that you can help bring about. Granted, if you're looking out 40 years, it's a different range of prospects than if you're looking out 10 years or five years or two years. You want to keep your mind focused on the longer range possibilities, but you've got to deal with today's questions in order to get there. That leads you into some tension, between what is advisable from the standpoint of tomorrow's deadlines and what is advisable from the standpoint of probable effectiveness of future relations 30 or 40 years out.

Frankly I found no one at Harvard who understood a thing about these issues. I think I understood them much better than they did

Latter Day Toxic Avengers

Carolyn Mayer

10

A study concluded that the biggest risk of living near a storage facility during operation is truck accidents

On a summer day in 1991, families from Ellington, Connecticut and adjoining communities gathered at a local playing field to rally against the siting of a low–level radioactive waste storage facility in their community. Many small–town people turned activists scouted the field for signatures to their petitions against the proposed siting of this facility. A couple of people wore cow costumes, apparently as mascots for the group called Citizens Opposed to Waste (cow). Other people wore gas masks and white coveralls to depict their fear of the radioactive threat and almost everyone wore orange bands as a sign of opposition.

An array of speakers took turns at a podium constructed of hay, all addressing the issue of fear for the health of the citizens of Ellington, and the subject of the survival of farms located near the reactor. Finally, a special keynote speaker, the Reverend Jesse Jackson, stepped up to the podium.

In his speech, Jackson gave voice to the fears of the crowd:

"What is radioactive waste? Can a body absorb it? Is the water safe if you drink it? How many drinks do you need to no longer be a living being?"

Jackson spoke with a sense of authority which left many listeners in dread.[1]

Across the country, residents of towns like Ellington have become alarmed upon learning that they might host a low level radioactive waste (LLRW) storage facility. Many residents are angered at the prospect of having such a facility in their backyard — or any "dump" for that matter — because they believe that it will drastically reduce the property values in their communities. For these citizens, the fundamental issue is quite simple: will the presence of LLRW detract from their quality of life? Bearing these concerns in mind, states, scientists, and nuclear facility experts have sought to assure a wary public that adequate safeguards are already in place to protect the surrounding environment. Potentially affected residents, however, remain unimpressed. Ironically, by opposing LLRW facilities, residents' fears for their personal safety will become a self–fulfilling prophecy. As it becomes increasingly difficult to dispose of LLRW, states must resort to storing such waste in temporary sites — which will, in turn, pose a threat to communities' safety.

Given the past history of some LLRW facilities, residents may have some legitimate grounds for concern. Three former low–level radioactive waste disposal sites in Illinois, Kentucky, and New York, built in the 1960s, both "either leaked radioactive material into ground water or contaminated surrounding soil." Although all three dumps were closed in the 1970s, some environmental activists insist that new dumps would be just as "environmentally risky, even as their proponents insist technology has improved."[2] Mitzi Bowman, founder of "Don't Waste Connecticut," fears that LLRW facilities "would be sited close to schools, hospitals, to people's lives and businesses and even to farmlands where radioactive waste can get into the food chain."[3] People, however, who take the time to examine the potential danger, rather than becoming cowed by it, may discover their fears to have been wildly exaggerated.

The whole issue regarding the proper disposal of radioactive waste became the topic of national debate in the wake of the nuclear accident at Three Mile Island in 1979. The type of waste stored at Three Mile Island, however, was what is commonly known as "hot" waste, which includes spent fuel from nuclear power plants or high–level reprocessed wastes. As a result of the leaks at the three low–level dumps in the 1970s, and disasters such as Three Mile Island, the national debate expanded to include the proper method of disposing LLRW.

After the three low–level disposal sites were closed in the 1970s, the federal government offered incentives to states if they agreed to build new LLRW sites. Three states accepted the offer: Nevada, South Carolina, and Washington. The residents of these states, however, complained that the disposal of LLRW from all fifty states into these three sites was unfair. The concerns of the residents of these three states, coupled with greater national attention in the wake of Three Mile Island, led to the passage of The Radioactive Policy Act of 1980. This law placed the burden of siting new LLRW

Carolyn Mayer will graduate from the School of Forestry and Environmental Studies this May. Kirby Lunger, a junior in Ezra Stiles, contributed to the writing and researching of this article.

storage facilities on each of the fifty states.

In early 1992, however, the State of New York prevailed in a court case which ruled that the Radioactive Waste Policy Act violated the states' sovereignty.[4] Consequently, the burden of siting LLRW storage facilities was shifted to the federal government. The federal government, therefore, bears the onus of siting these facilities in any of the fifty states; it must identify potential communities which offer optimal storage conditions. The siting of such facilities is a very difficult process. Aside from the political complications, it is nearly impossible to find sites in every state which can be classified as "safe" locations for the permanent storage of radioactive waste. This complex group of variables leads to the selection of only a small number of sites in each state. Community activists like those in Ellington mobilize to prevent these sites from being located near their residences. What the majority of American citizens do not realize, however, is that they face more, not less, danger from low level radiation if they blindly oppose low–level waste facilities from being established.

The Low–Level Waste Policy Act originally mandated that states either build their own sites to store low level radioactive materials, or that they form "compacts" with other states in order to dispose of their waste. The Act did provide one "carrot" for the states who allowed waste from other states to be deposited: these states could reject from their facilities any unwelcome out–of–state waste. Since the federal government must now locate sites in all fifty states, the last facility which still accepts out–of–state waste will close its doors to non–compact members this July. Consequently, all of the producers of radioactive waste in states without their own disposal sites will have to store LLRW where it is created.

This situation, at first glance, may not seem to pose a problem. After all, if some types of LLRW are separated from higher–level radioactive waste, they can essentially be thrown away with normal trash. "If you separate your waste, a lot of it is very, very low level and can go out in the garbage dump," said Dr. Carol Marcus, director of the nuclear medicine outpatient clinic at Harbor–UCLA Medical Center.[5] The low–level waste left over after this type of disposal, however, must be carefully stored on site. Despite precautions, such as using lead–enclosed boxes and rooms protected from extreme temperatures and humidity, specialist William Lukens, executive director of a Michigan coalition of radioactive material users, warns:

"You're going to have an act of nature, like a flood or a tornado, that could destroy the buildings which are being used as temporary storage facilities."[6]

The type of facility, against which many community groups in Connecticut and elsewhere are fighting, contains safeguards designed to prevent this type of accident from occurring. The favored construction plans for newly planned LLRW storage facilities employ a multi–barrier, or containerized, system. In these sites, trucks bring dry, solid waste to the storage facility, in tightly secured 55 gallon drums or steel lined containers. These drums or containers are placed in a 200 cubic foot concrete vault. That vault is then sealed off, and a crane lifts the vault into another concrete container, called a module, which is designed to hold about 16 of the smaller vaults. After filling the module with sand and sealing it with a concrete roof, cranes place the module among other sealed modules in a subsurface or ground level area. The storage site has a sloped floor in order to drain water away from the stored containers. Once a portion of the site is filled with modules, a multiple layer earthen cap is laid on top of them. This cap consists the following layers, starting from the bottom: sand, a flexible impermeable layer, sand, clay, sand and gravel, top soil, and vegetation.[7]

The manner in which these facilities are built prevents groundwater from becoming contaminated. "If water reaches the waste, it gets into your trench or into your disposal unit and migrates out of the area and brings radioactive material with it into the groundwater," said Amarello. According to Dr. David Brown, who was the Governor of Connecticut's designee to study the health effects of low level radioactive waste, as a result of regulations and precise engineering, the health risks involved with low level radioactive waste facilities are "really low or none at all because of the monitoring which is going on and the fact that the site is put together as such an integral system that nothing can leak off."[8]

Engineering and management are integral aspects of the successful operation of a low level radioactive waste storage facility, but the siting of the facility is equally important. When siting a low level radioactive waste facility, a siting council, composed of a variety of science and policy professionals, takes the following requirements into serious consideration. The structure must be isolated from surface and subsurface sources of drinking water and the area cannot be subject to predictable flooding or severe weather conditions that would adversely affect the facility before or after its closure. The facility must also have easy access to safe transportation routes and must be located in areas with low population densities. In addition, the site must have minimal impact on land uses and environmental resources, such as parks and forests, in its vicinity.

Furthermore, low level radioactive waste facilities have very complex monitoring systems which regularly test radiation concentrations in the groundwater, surface water, soil and air. As a South Carolina Department of Health environmental summary demonstrates, "...the low level

Natural background levels to which most people are annually exposed far exceed the amount of radiation a person receives from a LLRW storage facility

In America, while states have jurisdiction over education, standardized public school programs are decided upon by the individual districts.[7] "Connecticut mandates very little in terms of sex education. It operates under 'local control,' which means that each individual (school) board determines almost everything," commented Veronica Skerker, a comprehensive health education consultant for the Connecticut Department of Education.[8] Although there is a statute which grants schools permission to offer "Family Life" education (usually considered a euphemism for sex education), namely Connecticut Statute 10–16 DEFG, Skerker explains that mandating a statute which states that "we have to have sex education would be a very unusual step for (the state) to take."

The teaching methods of two Connecticut school districts serve to illustrate the vast differences in the sex education programs of Connecticut school districts. During the 1987–1988 academic year, the district of Milford implemented its current curriculum dealing with sex education, the "Family Living" courses. The district appointed a committee of teachers, parents, members of the clergy, school board officials, and physicians to design the new sex education program.This group agreed to include factual, not value–based, information on sexual reproduction and contraception in the program. Although, on average, Americans first engage in sexual intercourse at 16.2 years of age for females and 15.7 years of age for males, the information on contraception included in the "Family Living" course is offered only in grades eleven and twelve[9].

In contrast to the Milford program, the "Family Life Education" courses in the Amity Regional School District (Bethany, Orange and Woodbridge), discuss contraception with the purpose of preventing STDs, AIDS and pregnancy in the tenth grade. The "Contemporary Life Skills — Taking Charge" course elective offered in the ninth grade in this district teaches students how to apply decision–making skills specifically to the area of sexuality. By reinforcing the application of decision–making skills to sexuality, this program conforms to research findings that show that simply to provide information (as is done in Milford schools) will not adequately achieve desired behavior modification.[10]

Americans first engage in sexual intercourse at 16.2 years of age for females and 15.7 years of age for males

The example of the extreme differences in content between the sex education programs of neighboring school boards in Connecticut underscores the need for a sex education program mandated at the federal level, as are specific programs in drug abuse prevention education and special education. Skerker explains that because such federally sponsored programs are subject to very little content regulation, simply to sponsor a national sex education program would not provide a "national mandate" regarding every aspect of the content of sex education programs, but would require the teaching of some basic facts which are necessary for health and safety.

Skerker argues, however, that the United States lacks the necessary criteria to succeed in providing a national sex education program. The first criterion, the absence of a centralized educational system, has already been discussed. The second concerns Americans' certainty about their own sexuality. Skerker holds that Americans are generally confused about sex. She explains that today's parents were raised with the traditional stereotypes and gender roles of the 1950s. During their formative years, which coincided with the sexual revolution of the 1960s, many rejected these values. Consequently, now that they are parents, "they don't know what to convey, so they convey nothing." In fact, some parents feel so ill–equipped to teach their children about sex that they themselves enroll in sex education classes.[11] The third characteristic missing in the United States is a homogeneous culture. Many sub–cultures within the United States ascribe to different sexual norms, and therefore a simplified national program that ignores these differences would be ineffective. Skerker believes that the success of Sweden's national sex education mandate is due in part to that nation's cultural homogeneity. An analysis of sex education programs in other nations suggests, however, that a national sex education plan for the United States would actually succeed.

First of all, it seems questionable that the country's lack of cultural homogeneity would prevent national sex education from being effective. The largest impediment to successful sex education in Latin America, for example, derives from its very cultural homogeneity — which promotes a tradition of misinformation that is difficult to modify. Traditionally, in Latin America, sex education has not been included in primary or secondary school curricula, not to mention in higher education. There have been, however, recent efforts to incorporate material on reproductive health within the school curriculum. According to a study completed in 1992 by the Pan American Health Organization in Latin America and the Caribbean, several pervasive daily–life situations are closely linked to problems identified in the area of reproductive health. These include the ignorance and fear that envelop sexual behavior, lack of knowledge of the body and its reproductive functions, machismo, discrimination against women, unplanned growth of families, undesired pregnancies and limited participation of fathers in raising their children.[12] Sex education within such a context "can have an impact on

culture through the questioning of attitudes and norms of behavior when such attitudes and behavior constitute an obstacle to individuals, families and communal well–being."[13]

The American social structure differs considerably. There are many legal resources that pressure fathers to provide financial support for raising their children. In addition, the media glorify – and thereby diminish the fear of — sex. The media, moreover, regularly update the public with the latest data on STDs, especially AIDS. Furthermore, the United States has a greater health support system for, and available literature on, family planning and contraception.

Indeed, despite the lack of cultural homogeneity in the United States, many social requirements for successful sex education are already in place in this nation. These social structures are available to nearly all citizens by virtue of the fact that they live in the same country, regardless of cultural background. One characteristic of American social structures, albeit implicit, is the belief that human sexuality is a valid area of inquiry: hospitals employ sexologists, the media present sexually explicit material, and many schools offer some kind of sex education. As a result, virtually thousands of Americans have careers which involve the study of human sexuality.

The Clinton Administration recently passed the "Goals 2000: Educate America Act" which aims to standardize education goals across the nation. This law mandates the creation of a President–appointed committee called the "National Education Standards and Improvement Council" (NESIC) to draw up national guidelines which states must implement in order to receive federal funding.

In an interview with *The Los Angeles Times*, Secretary of Education Richard W. Riley was asked to comment on how today's schools face more serious issues than they did in the past — such as violence and AIDS. In light of Goals 2000, he responded:

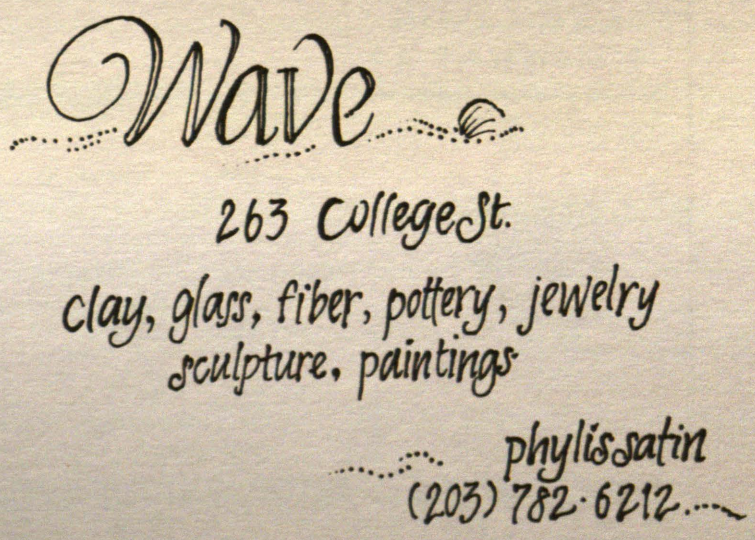
What I say to people is identify your needs, find out what your special problems are. If it is teenage pregnancy, then you have a need to deal with it. Don't not deal with it. It's not my place to tell you how to deal with it.[14]

Riley seems to have forgotten that issues such as teenage pregnancy and AIDS are not specifically local problems, but rather issues that no school can afford to ignore. Teenage pregnancy and HIV are topics that must be explicitly addressed in a sex education program initiative that would be standardized, nationalized, and included in Goals 2000. After all, with both the rate of AIDS cases and of teenage pregnancy on the rise, Clinton's "Goals 2000" will be of no avail if American adolescents do not live long enough or healthily enough to put their education to use.

Notes

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Clinton's "Goals 2000" will be of no avail if American adolescents do not live long enough or healthily enough to put their education to use



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